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The Texture of a Season: Abstraction and Emotion in Roland Petersen's *Spring Luncheon*

When I first saw Roland Petersen's *Spring Luncheon*, I got hit with a feeling that is both striking and puzzling: it is abstract, yet still distinguishable. This tension between abstraction and legibility is at the heart of what makes the painting so compelling, and it is a tension that Petersen created with his skillful hands. Through his deliberate formal choices, color, contrast, and the selective omission of detail, Petersen does not simply depict a scene. He captures a feeling.

Perhaps the best of *Spring Luncheon* lies in the choice of colors. In particular, the colors chosen are the epitome of spring: soft pinks, warm yellows, fresh greens, and open sky blues sweep across the canvas in bold strokes. However, what elevates this palette beyond a pleasant feeling is the integration of darker hues. Thick slashes of deep indigo, dark teal, and heavy crimson cut across the center of the canvas, carving a stark boundary between the picnic and the horizon. Rather than disrupting the sunlit mood, these dark, weighty tones provide a structural contrast and shape, grounding the composition and giving the lighter yellow and soft pink strokes a vivid backdrop against which to truly breathe and expand. What piqued my interest is that this combination of light and dark is not accidental. Petersen demonstrates an unmatched sense of color value, an understanding of how colors relate to one another in terms of lightness and darkness, and how those relationships can be used to create depth, movement, and emotional resonance. The result is a canvas that feels alive.

Looking beyond the color, the composition reveals another layer of meaning. The heavy, vertical bands representing 'trees' slice straight down the left side of the canvas, while thick, rectangular 'sheets' of vibrant color stretch horizontally across the middle ground. These stark geometric planes frame the composition, drawing the eye down to the cluster of round 'plates of food' gathered on the bright white tablecloth in the lower right foreground. None of these objects is painted with precision or photographic accuracy. Instead, Petersen uses a heavy impasto technique, heavily layering the oil paint so that the physical texture of the canvas mirrors the energy of the season. Because of this dense, layered brushwork, the objects do not require clean lines. Instead, they emerge from the ridges of the paint itself, existing in the form of rich, tactile suggestions and impressions. This “lack” of detail, for me, is not a flaw, but is one of the painting’s best decisions. By stripping away the specificity that would attach the scene to a particular time, place, or person, Petersen gives the painting a universal feeling. The picnic in *Spring Luncheon* does not belong to any one family or afternoon. It belongs to everyone who has ever felt the warmth of a spring day.

That universality is perhaps the painting’s greatest achievement, and it is what makes the emotional response to it so genuine. *Spring Luncheon* is not a depiction of spring specific to anyone. It is Spring as a feeling. Standing before it, I am filled with warmth, and it is possible to feel the sun shining down. The painting does not ask the viewer to remember a particular memory or recognize a specific place. It asks only that they open themselves to a season, to the easy joy and unhurried light that the word “spring” stuck in the mind. Petersen achieves this not through detail but through its absence, not through realism but through color and form working together in harmony.

Lastly, one thing that I also love about *Spring Luncheon* is that it rewards continued attention. It is one of those paintings where the longer you stare at it, the more you love it. With each return of the eye, new relationships between colors become visible, new shapes appear from the layered brushwork, and a new feeling of warmth and light make themselves known. Petersen's painting does not give itself up all at once. It unfolds gradually, like the season it portrays. In this way, the viewer does not merely observe the scene; they participate in it. *Spring Luncheon* is not simply a painting about spring. It is, in its very structure and experience, an act of spring.



Work cited

Petersen, Roland. *Spring Luncheon*. 1961, Jan Shrem and Maria Manetti Shrem Museum of Art,

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